And yet, in the opinion of the British military attaché in Tehran, Lieutenant-Colonel Saunders, the propaganda that Rothstein had been distributing 'has produced remarkably small results when one takes into consideration the numerous staff employed and large sums expended by him'.[22] Major Bray of the India Office concurred in this judgement, pointing out that 'the Bolsheviks have admitted that their Communist activities in Persia had not...met with great success'.[23] In fact, according to Bolshevik figures, by 1922 there were only 2,000 declared Communists within Persia.[24] As Loraine noted, 'bolshevism [sic] among the Persians themselves is losing its early glamour'.[25] It seemed that, despite his best efforts, Rothstein was faced with that perennial issue of the fundamental incompabatability of Communism and Islam.

It was not just from the Russian side that things were unsatisfactory. In January 1922 Oliphant noted how the Persians appeared disappointed that their agreement had not brought about better relations with the Soviet government.[26] One person within the Persian government who was finding relations with the Bolsheviks particularly difficult was Reza Khan, minister of war and – since 1921 – arguably the strongest personality within the Persian government.[27] The British government had always held mixed views on Reza Khan. By replacing British control of the Cossack Division with Persian officers, and by involving himself in various governmental intrigues, Reza Khan had gained the suspicions of some British figures. Norman believed that the minister of war was 'an ignorant peasant' and 'not to be trusted',[28] while Armitage-Smith argued that the man was 'entirely in the hands of...Rothstein' who found it easy to manipulate the lower-born, lesser-educated Persian.[29]

Loraine was more positive about Reza Khan, however, believing him to be far more practical than most Persian political figures.[30] Victor Mallet, a legation staffer, was also well disposed towards the Persian minister:

Our essential interests in Persia demand a stable and strong central government, able to resist Russian penetration and the spread of Communist propaganda, to keep order on the trade routes, in the oil fields district and in